India in South Africa, November 1992–January 1993

It was a historic tour because it was the first time the South Africans had played a Test series at home since returning to the international fold in 1991. They had toured India in November 1991 to end their international isolation after twenty-one years and in the three one-day internationals showed they were a very good side. In Allan Donald they had one of the best fast bowlers in the world and he was ably supported by Richard Snell, Brian McMillan, Craig Matthews, Meyrick Pringle, Brett Schultz and a host of other really good bowlers. In South African conditions the fast bowlers would pose a serious challenge.

The United Cricket Board of South Africa had made every effort to make the tour memorable. We landed in Durban and were immediately met by the hosts, who put us in open-top cars. There were two cricketers in each car and hordes of people lined the road as we made our way to the hotel. I was in a car with Pravin Amre, a middle-order bat and another of Ramakant Achrekar's students, and remember listening to Kishore Kumar songs all the way to the hotel. It was a fabulous experience.

We played our first tour game against Nicky Oppenheimer's XI at his private ground in Randjesfontein. It had rained heavily before the start of the game and it looked highly unlikely that we would get any cricket on the day. But I had underestimated our hosts and was totally taken aback to see what they were pouring onto the pitch to dry it out. They actually burnt petrol on the pitch to expedite the drying process, something I had never imagined could happen. That wasn't all. To our surprise, a couple of helicopters hovered over the ground to dry the pitch for a good forty-five minutes. As a result of all this effort, the pitch was finally playable and we managed to get a game. I made a hundred and we won the match easily, making a very good start to the tour. Afterwards, the talk in the dressing room was that we would beat the South Africans easily. We carried this sense of complacency into the next match, where we scored over 500 runs against a Combined Bowl XI after bowling them out for 230. The tour was turning out to be a walk in the park.

Things changed dramatically when we played the South African Board President's XI at Centurion on 6 November 1992. We bowled first and, standing at slip, I could see that the ball was not carrying through to